

thought possible, especially given their relatively low cost. For this reason a growing number of small to medium-sized businesses (SMBs) such as accounting firms, doctor's offices, and law firms are relying on wireless LANs (WLANs) to connect computers and expand their networks. However, as with any new technology, there are always disadvantages that must be considered as part of the overall picture. With WLANs, the downside that stands out the most is the technology's inherent information security vulnerabilities. Why is information security such a big deal?

For starters, many people believe that their electronic information is not at risk. This is simply not true. Most hackers are not "professionals" but rather teenagers and young adults who are looking to break in just because they can. They download a selection of hacking programs that are alarmingly easy to use. All they're looking for is somewhere to use them. Remember, most hackers aren't targeting you any more than a thief targets your house. They are only looking for a target of convenience. Once they find a WLAN they can crack, they do so, not knowing in most cases whose system they're breaking into. They are merely looking for systems to compromise whether or not there are huge tangible payoffs.

There's also the issue of disgruntled employees. In this case, you are the desired target. But regardless of intent, your business relies on computers more and more to keep up with the times and stay competitive. This means an increasing amount of information is being processed and stored electronically and, therefore, is in turn made vulnerable to outside attacks. Insecure WLAN usage is making this problem bigger than ever before.

Another information security misconception is that once the cost of firewalls, anti-virus software, and other security solutions are introduced—however small they may be—those costs will far outweigh the need for information security. In addition to the monetary aspect, many people believe that the time, effort, and